

ORIGINAL ARTICLE

Mechanisms of Checks and Balances: Appropriations, Congressional Committees, and Interbranch Conflict

Jeremiah Cha¹  | Jon Rogowski²¹Department of Government, Harvard University, Cambridge, Massachusetts, USA | ²Department of Political Science, University of Chicago, Chicago, Illinois, USA**Correspondence:** Jeremiah Cha (jeremiahcha@g.harvard.edu)**Received:** 17 December 2024 | **Revised:** 26 June 2025 | **Accepted:** 14 July 2025**ABSTRACT**

We study how committees influence policy outcomes in the context of appropriations. Since the birth of modern political science, the power of the purse has been recognized as a primary institutional check through which Congress constrains presidential ambitions. Despite the importance of committees and subcommittees in classic accounts of appropriations, recent developments raise questions about their relevance for contemporary legislative outcomes. We test the hypothesis that appropriations outcomes are less aligned with the president's request as the relevant subcommittee is more ideologically distant from the president. Using comprehensive new data on presidential budget requests and congressional appropriations for the U.S. federal government from 1972 to 2021, we find strong support for this expectation, particularly in the House. Our findings suggest that the composition of legislative committees affects policy outcomes and illustrate how the (sub)committee system helps Congress overcome its collective action problems to constrain the executive.

Do committees influence policymaking in the contemporary United States Congress? The conditional party government perspective suggests that polarization between parties and homogeneity within parties empowers party leaders at the expense of congressional committees (Aldrich and Rohde 1997, 2000; Rohde 1991).¹ These ideological shifts suggest a declining role for committees in producing legislation and shaping legislative debates. Observers of Congress have noted similar trends, lamenting the “disintegration of the committee process” (Cohen et al. 2004) and the “decline of committees as policy makers” (Wolfensberger 2012, 5). Scholars who emphasize the important functions committees serve in the contemporary Congress nonetheless point out that committees increasingly prioritize activities such as oversight over policy deliberations (Lewallen 2020; Kornberg 2023). Yet other research argues that committees continue to exercise policy influence (Evans 2011) and that special interests perceive committees to be important sites of policymaking (Teso 2025) even as the mechanisms through which committees affect legislation have changed over time (Curry 2019).

We study the role of committees in influencing appropriations outcomes. Given that classic scholarship emphasizes Congress's tendency to delegate appropriations decisions to the relevant subcommittees (Fenno 1966; Kingdon 1966; MacMahon 1943), we focus on the appropriations subcommittees. In this context, we evaluate the role of subcommittees in shaping Congress's response to presidential budget requests. The power of the purse is a key Article I power and a crucial mechanism in the separation of powers. Legislative control over appropriations is “[o]ne of Congress's main tools to push back at... presidential unilateralism” (Metzger 2021, 1153) and “the most important single curb in the Constitution on presidential power” (Corwin 1978, 134).

We evaluate whether the composition of the relevant appropriations subcommittee affects a president's success in bargaining over the budget. If the subcommittees affect appropriations outcomes, we expect that congressional appropriations outcomes are less aligned with the president's request as the relevant subcommittee is more ideologically distant from the president. Our

argument suggests that in the current era of polarization and dysfunction, the (sub)committee system provides a mechanism by which Congress overcomes its collective action problems to constrain the executive.

We make five main contributions. First, while classical perspectives argue that subcommittees evaluate presidential budget requests based on norms of fiscal responsibility (Fenno 1966), we argue that subcommittee members evaluate presidents' budget requests based on their ideological orientation vis-à-vis the president. Second, even as polarization has increased gridlock and complicated Congress's ability to make collective decisions (e.g., Binder 2015), we show that subcommittees perform the function of the broader Congress in enforcing its power of the purse. Third, our findings highlight the policy relevance of congressional committees in the contemporary era (see also Curry 2019) even as Congress has increasingly turned to omnibus appropriations legislation (e.g., Hanson 2014). Fourth, we show how interbranch conflict limits presidents' ability to secure their policy goals, complementing other means through which Congress constrains the administrative presidency (e.g., Bolton and Thrower 2021; Howell 2003; Kriner and Schickler 2016). Fifth, we contribute to scholarship that theorizes how committee composition affects legislative outcomes (Adler 2000; Krehbiel 1990, 1991; McGrath and Ryan 2019; Shepsle and Weingast 1985). Though our focus is on the United States, our perspective relates to scholarship on the role of parliamentary committees in constraining ministries and executive agencies (see, e.g., Longley and Davidson 1998).

We introduce comprehensive data on presidential budget requests and enacted appropriations from fiscal years 1972 to 2021. We match these data to the subcommittee exercising jurisdiction over each request and characterize the ideological composition of each subcommittee's membership. Using these data, we show that enacted appropriations increasingly differ from the president's proposal when the ideological distance increases between the president and the median subcommittee member. These results are driven primarily by ideological conflict between the president and members of the House appropriations subcommittees and are robust across a range of model specifications, estimation strategies, and measurement choices. Moreover, these results are not driven by strategic presidential behavior in developing budgetary requests or variation in partisan control of Congress.

Our findings provide new evidence about how (sub)committee composition affects policy outcomes and illustrate a mechanism through which Congress constrains the president's agenda-setter advantage in budgetary politics. In this respect, our work complements Bolton and Thrower (2019) in emphasizing the importance of congressional subcommittees in constraining the exercise of presidential discretion and influence. In an era of rampant partisan polarization, narrow legislative majorities, and concerns about growing congressional dysfunction (e.g., Levinson and Pildes 2006), the work of the small appropriations subcommittees enables the broader legislature to perform its task of checking and balancing the executive.

1 | Congressional Committees and Legislative Outcomes

Committees and parties are the two primary organizational structures in the US Congress. Over the last half-century, legislative influence appears to have shifted from the former to the latter. Congressional committees once were "the central organizational feature of Congress" (Evans 2011, 411), and, as a result, "[c]ongressional policymaking [was] largely committee-centered" (Price 1972, 10). Yet as power has become more centralized within the chambers, majority party leaders rather than committees have exercised greater control over the legislative process (Aldrich and Rohde 1997, 2000; Chergosky and Roberts 2018; Rohde 1991). In turn, the increased use of unorthodox procedures by party leaders has limited opportunities for committees to influence legislation (Bendix 2016; Hanson 2014; Sinclair 2016).²

Yet the decline-of-committee thesis (see also Wolfensberger 2012) need not imply the irrelevance of committees in the contemporary Congress. As Curry (2019) argues, committee members use their specialized policy expertise to shape the behavior of their colleagues and thus influence legislative outcomes. This perspective suggests that committees today exercise power through more informal means relative to the committees of the post-reform Congress, yet they wield influence nonetheless. Other scholarship suggests that committee influence is more conditional. For example, Vander Wielen (2010) shows that conference committees can shift legislative outcomes toward their preferred direction so long as the legislation remains broadly acceptable to majorities in both chambers. Scholarship on the markup process also shows that party leaders are more likely to bypass committees in reviewing legislation when their ideological composition deviates from the preferences of the majority party (Bendix 2016). And Woon and Anderson (2012) show that Congress is slower to pass appropriations bills when there is greater ideological conflict between the median member of the majority party and the majority party members of the appropriations committee. Each of these findings suggests the opportunity for committees to independently influence legislative outcomes depending on their composition.

Moreover, the resilience of congressional organization centered around the committee system suggests its continued importance in modern legislative politics. According to Shepsle (1978), committees play a critical role in legislative bargaining by guaranteeing the existence of stable voting coalitions. This role also facilitates the administration of distributive benefits to members' districts. Other scholars, such as Krehbiel (1991), alternatively highlight committees' roles in providing information to serve the broader legislative chamber. Instead of catering to the needs of localized interests, this perspective views congressional committees as an agent of the broader chamber, allowing for a more efficient distribution of legislative resources. Both perspectives characterize the committee system as a source of influence given its ability to advance the interests of individual members as well as the collective chamber.

We study the policymaking influence of committees in appropriations outcomes. We focus particularly on the role of committees

in structuring congressional responses to presidential budgetary requests. Not only is appropriations a substantively important outcome, responsible for allocating nearly \$2 trillion dollars in annual discretionary spending, but it is also central to Congress's ability to constrain the president's control of the administrative state (Bolton and Thrower 2019). As Metzger (2021, 1077) writes, contemporary presidents often have incentives for "creatively interpret[ing] appropriations statutes, impos[ing] new grant conditions, repurpos[ing] and withhold[ing] funds, and invok[ing] inadequate funding as a basis for broad assertions of presidential discretion." Appropriations is also useful from a practical perspective, as debates over appropriations between Congress and the president concern concrete dollar figures. In contrast with most other areas of public policy, in which Congress and the president debate myriad provisions when writing new immigration policy or reforming the health care system, for example, these dollar figures provide a measurable way of evaluating the degree to which Congress accommodates the president's stated spending preferences.

1.1 | Congress, Appropriations, and the Separation of Powers

Presidents have incentives to direct policymaking activity within the executive branch. By staffing the bureaucracy with ideological allies (Lewis 2008), centralizing policymaking in the White House (Moe 1985), and issuing unilateral directives (Howell 2003), presidents have opportunities to create new policies and reshape existing ones. Yet the scope of presidents' policy influence is limited by their need for funding, without which their initiatives cannot be executed. As such, Congress's power over appropriations is a key mechanism for constraining presidents' efforts to control the executive branch. As McConachie (1898, 235) argued more than a century ago, it is "in the direction of administrative activity through the power of granting or withholding money... that Congress finds by far its greatest power over the Executive..."

Scholars have identified a number of factors associated with how well Congress accommodates the president's budgetary requests. Kiewiet and McCubbins (1988) show that veto power conveys asymmetric benefits to the president in bargaining over appropriations, as presidents have greater influence in setting appropriations policy when they prefer less spending to Congress but are less influential when they prefer more spending. Canes-Wrone (2001) shows that presidents are more successful in achieving their budgetary goals on proposals for which they have sought public support. Other studies show that Congress better accommodates presidential preferences during periods of war (Howell et al. 2013, chapter 4) and for agencies concerned with foreign affairs (Canes-Wrone et al. 2008).

We focus on the role of the Appropriations Committees and their various subcommittees in scrutinizing the president's budget requests. Previous research examines how the aggregated characteristics of Congress or its chambers affect legislative responses to presidential budgets (e.g., Canes-Wrone et al. 2008; Howell et al. 2013) but has not evaluated how subcommittee composition affects evaluations of presidents' requests. This is an important omission given that scholars have long recognized the

central role of the appropriations subcommittees in enacting the nation's budget (e.g., Fenno 1966; Geiger 1994; Kingdon 1966; MacMahon 1943).

1.2 | The Appropriations Subcommittees as a Source of Presidential Constraint

We argue that the composition of the appropriations subcommittees shapes congressional scrutiny of presidential budgets. Over the last century, the appropriations committees have been organized as 10 to 13 subcommittees, each of which has jurisdiction for appropriations related to some set of institutions within the federal government. The subcommittees review the president's spending requests, consult the financial estimates compiled by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) and the Congressional Budget Office, and issue reports that recommend spending levels and provide instructions for their expenditure. Given these arrangements, Geiger (1994, 398) argued that "the subcommittees are the most important actors" in Congress's review of the budget, and Kingdon (1966, 68) even more pointedly noted that "congressional decisions on agency budgets are made neither by the whole congress nor even by the full appropriations committees, but by subcommittees of the appropriations committee" (see also Davis et al. 1966, 530). These accounts make clear that the subcommittees are the locus of congressional decision-making on appropriations; therefore, the fate of presidential budget requests is largely in their hands. Based on our perspective, we expect that enacted appropriations better reflect a president's budgetary requests when members of the appropriations subcommittees are more ideologically congruent with the president.

Our argument assumes that subcommittee members evaluate a president's budget request based on how well it reflects their own preferences relative to the status quo. This characterization follows theoretical models in which legislators are posited to have preferences along an ideological continuum and support a given proposal if they prefer it to the status quo (Krehbiel 1998; Poole and Rosenthal 1991). To the extent that legislators and presidents have preferences over spending levels and are more supportive of appropriations that more closely reflect those preferences, a subcommittee is more likely to accommodate a president's budget request when it is more closely aligned with the president's ideological orientation. This characterization contrasts with classical scholarship, which argued that appropriators make spending decisions based on the norms into which committee members were socialized rather than on the basis of their spending preferences. Most prominently, Richard Fenno (1962, 311) argued that committee members perceived themselves as the "guardian[s] of public funds" and had incentives to cut spending from the president's request (see also Davis et al. 1966; Fenno 1966). While our account and this perspective both characterize subcommittees as sources of congressional constraint on presidents' budgetary preferences, they generate competing expectations about how Congress responds to presidential budgets.

Our account contributes to several bodies of scholarship, which to date have existed mostly separately. First, while previous research downplayed the possibility that subcommittee composition

affected appropriations decisions (White 1989, 201–203) or reshaped budgetary priorities (Geiger 1994, 414), this work did not directly examine how subcommittee membership affected congressional action on the president's budget.³ More recent scholarship shows that the ideological alignment of appropriations subcommittees with the president is associated with the budgetary discretion they give to agencies (Bolton and Thrower 2019) and the speed with which they pass spending bills (Woon and Anderson 2012). We extend these insights to argue that the appropriations subcommittees are an underappreciated source of congressional constraint on the president's budgetary goals. In addition, by studying how appropriations subcommittees shape budgetary outcomes, we examine claims that subcommittees are “vital to the policymaking process” (Shepsle and Weingast 1985, 118) and wield significant influence over collective committee decisions (Deering 1982; Hall and Evans 1990).

Second, our account implies a relationship between committee composition and policy outcomes. While our argument does not address the representativeness of the appropriations committees or their subcommittees (see, e.g., Groseclose 1994; Krehbiel 1990; McGrath and Ryan 2019), it does predict that their ideological composition is associated with congressional scrutiny of the president's budget. To the degree that appropriations subcommittees are unrepresentative of the chamber, our account implies that budgetary outcomes would better reflect the subcommittee's preferences rather than the median of the chamber.⁴

More broadly, our argument suggests that committee organization is an important mechanism through which Congress asserts its institutional prerogatives vis-à-vis the president. Previous research documents the role of political parties (e.g., Aldrich 1995) and intraparty organizations (e.g., Bloch Rubin 2017) in helping to solve collective action problems that often inhibit legislative action. Today's Congress is more polarized and more partisan than it once was (Binder 2015; Curry and Lee 2020; Moskowitz et al. 2024), and recent research documents Congress's institutional weaknesses in serving as a constraint on the exercise of unilateral power (Kaufman and Rogowski 2024). These observations may rightfully generate concern about Congress's ability to serve as an effective institutional counterweight to the presidency (e.g., Levinson and Pildes 2006). Other scholars likewise have highlighted the relatively limited capacity of majority parties (particularly in the Senate) to affect shifting appropriations outcomes in their preferred direction (Hanson 2014). As a complement to other scholarship that stresses the role of committee investigations led by entrepreneurial legislators in serving as a check on the presidency (e.g., Kriner and Schickler 2016), we show how the disaggregation of the chamber into small subunits enables the legislature to effectively pursue its preferences vis-à-vis the president in ways that may not be possible were it left to the entire chamber. Even in an era where congressional leaders are often characterized as having increased influence over the legislative process (Curry and Lee 2019, 60), our findings highlight the continued role and relevance of congressional committees in shaping legislative outcomes (see also Reynolds and Hanson 2023). In addition, scholars have long emphasized the importance of Congress's power of the purse, and we highlight the specific role of the appropriations subcommittees in enforcing this advantage.

2 | Data

We test our argument using an original dataset of presidential budget requests and congressional enactments for fiscal years 1972 to 2021. We collected this data from the Budget of the United States, issued annually by the OMB. The Budget of the United States contains narrative descriptions of presidential policy priorities as well as detailed presidential requests and congressional enactment figures disaggregated by federal subunit.⁵ We collected values for the proposed values from each fiscal year's Budget of the United States, while enacted values were collected from those values published in the Budget of the United States two years after the proposal.⁶

Our dataset represents the most comprehensive compilation of these discretionary budgetary figures assembled to date.⁷ These data build upon foundational work by Fenno (1966) and Kiewiet and McCubbins (1991), who analyzed spending patterns for a sample of 77 agencies and laid the foundation for subsequent empirical work on separation of powers (Canes-Wrone 2001; Canes-Wrone et al. 2008; Howell et al. 2013). Generically, our data include requested and enacted appropriations for subunits (often representing offices, agencies, and bureaus) nested within units (often departments or independent agencies) for each fiscal year.⁸ Our data contain information on 626 unique unit-subunits with a total of 10,800 observations. Descriptions of the data are shown in Appendix A.1.

Figure 1 shows total presidential requests and congressional enactments by fiscal year, in real dollars (standardized to the 2022 calendar year). In aggregate, the average annual difference between congressional enactments and presidential requests is about \$800 billion. The figure shows both that the size of the budget has grown over time and that presidents' success in achieving their preferred outcomes has varied. In some years, for example, the difference between requested and enacted appropriations is vanishingly small (e.g., during most of the Clinton administration), while in other years the gap between requested and enacted appropriations is larger

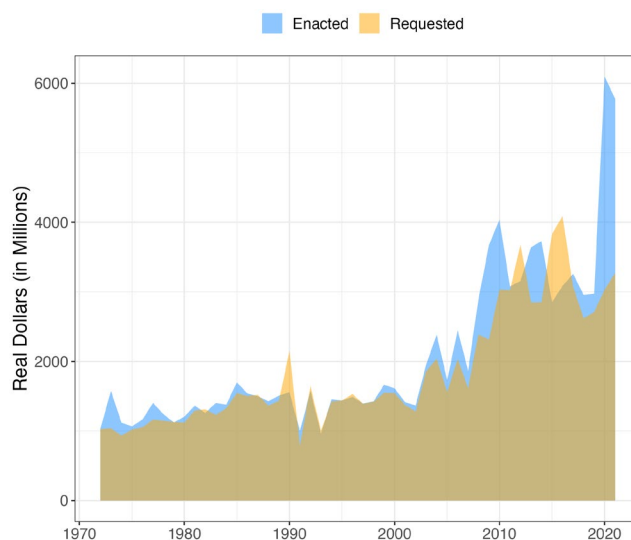


FIGURE 1 | Total requested and enacted appropriations, FY1972 to FY2021.

in both absolute and percentage terms (e.g., most fiscal years during the Nixon, George W. Bush, Obama, and Trump administrations).

We then linked each subunit in our appropriations data to the respective subcommittee in each chamber with jurisdiction over it. To do so, we primarily rely on House Appropriation bills (similar to Adler 2000), which list subunits disaggregated by subcommittee jurisdiction. We also use reports published by the HAC that detail more recent jurisdictional divisions and House hearing transcripts for more historical jurisdictional divisions. Most subunits can be directly matched to appropriation bills, though in a few cases subunits are listed in the annual budget reports but not explicitly in the appropriation bills of the given year.⁹ While in some instances it was possible to match these subunits to the relevant subcommittees, we omitted from the analyses the several hundred observations for which the available information was insufficient for making an informed judgment about which subcommittee oversaw appropriations decisions.

The appropriations subcommittee system was reorganized several times during the period under study. As an illustration, Figure A.2 summarizes the subcommittee composition of the HAC and its representation in our data. From 1971 to 2003, the HAC was organized into 13 subcommittees.¹⁰ Following the creation of the Department of Homeland Security, the 108th Congress added a Subcommittee on Homeland Security and merged the subcommittees on Transportation and on Treasury, Postal Service, and General Government. In the next Congress, the HAC was reorganized into 10 subcommittees by disbanding two subcommittees and reorganizing their respective jurisdictions into other subcommittees. In the 110th Congress, the Subcommittee on the Legislative Branch was reconstituted, and the Subcommittee on Transportation and Treasury was separated.

Finally, to measure the ideological composition of the subcommittees, we compiled complete rosters of all subcommittees along with the identity of the relevant chair from the House Appropriation Committee Semi-Annual Report of Committee Activities, published by each Congress, and the United States Senate (2022).¹¹

3 | Empirical Strategy

The dependent variable in our analysis is presidential success in achieving their budgetary preferences. As previous scholarship has noted (Canes-Wrone et al. 2008), appropriations is a particularly good context for studying a president's bargaining success. By comparing what presidents requested to what Congress enacted, we have a clear and continuous measure of the degree to which Congress accommodated the president's policy preferences. We operationalize this quantity as the difference between presidential requests and congressional enactments (for a similar approach, see Sharkansky 1965b, 626–627). Specifically, we follow Howell et al. (2013) and calculate the dependent variable as $\ln(1 + |\text{Requested}_{it} - \text{Enacted}_{it}|)$ for each subunit i in fiscal year t . Larger values of this measure indicate greater differences between what the president requested and what Congress enacted.¹²

Our primary independent variable characterizes the ideological distance between the president and the relevant subcommittee. Following models of committee decision-making (Black 1958), we measure this quantity for each chamber using the absolute value of the ideological difference between the president and the median subcommittee member using first-dimension NOMINATE scores (Lewis et al. 2022).¹³ This approach is similar to that used in Woon and Anderson (2012), where larger values indicate greater ideological disagreement between a president and a subcommittee.¹⁴ Based on these calculations, we characterize *Subcommittee distance* as the greater of the ideological distances between the president and the median of the relevant House and Senate subcommittees. As we discuss below, we also explore model specifications that focus on the ideological distance between the president and the subcommittee medians in each chamber.

Using the measures described above, we estimate the following model:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha_i + \gamma_p + \beta \text{ Subcommittee distance}_{it} + \Omega X_{it} + \epsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

where the dependent variable is the difference between requested and enacted appropriations and i indexes the subunits in our data. *Subcommittee distance* is the measure described above, which we rescale by dividing by its standard deviation to facilitate interpretation. With this rescaled measure, a one-unit increase represents a 0.29 increase in subcommittee distance, similar to the difference in ideological orientations between representatives Hakeem Jeffries (D-NY; -0.49) and Abigail Spanberger (D-VA; -0.175). The coefficient estimate for β is our primary quantity of interest. If presidents are less successful in achieving their preferred budgetary outcomes as the relevant subcommittee is more ideologically distant from them, as we argue, we expect to find a positive estimate for this parameter.

Our primary specification includes fixed effects for subunits (α_i) and presidential administrations (γ_p). The former accounts for systematic differences in interbranch bargaining that vary across the myriad subunits in our data. For example, some subunits may be more politically salient and thus subjected to greater congressional scrutiny than others. By including presidency fixed effects, we hold constant the attributes of individual presidents that may be associated with bargaining outcomes. With this model specification, the estimate for β is identified with changes in subcommittee distance that occur within presidential administrations.

We also account for other congressional and economic factors X_{it} that may be associated with a president's bargaining success. First, we control for the president's appropriations request—that is, $\ln(\text{Requested}_{it})$ —as Congress is more likely to accommodate the president's requests for smaller expenditures than larger ones. Second, we account for periods of divided government, as Congress may be less likely to accommodate the president's budgetary request when a larger share is controlled by the other party (Kiewiet and McCubbins 1985a, 1985b).¹⁵ Third, because presidents are given more budgetary latitude during periods of war (Howell et al. 2013), we include an indicator corresponding to the Vietnam, Persian Gulf, and post-9/11 wars in Iraq and

Afghanistan. Economic factors may also have implications for presidential bargaining success, as declining economic circumstances may provide presidents with less leverage for obtaining their policy preferences (Woon and Anderson 2012). Thus, we also include measures of the annual unemployment rate, the year-over-year percentage change in real gross domestic product (GDP), and the size of the budget deficit in real terms from the previous year.

Finally, in all our models we estimate standard errors clustered on subcommittees, the level at which values of subcommittee distance are assigned. However, because our data include a relatively small number of clusters (i.e., fewer than 50; see Cameron and Miller 2015), without further adjustment our standard errors are likely to be biased downward. To address this issue, we estimate standard errors with the wild clustered bootstrap with 100,000 iterations (Fischer and Roodman 2021). We follow conventions in the literature and thus report *p*-values in our tables rather than standard errors.

4 | Results

Table 1 presents our main results. The first column reports results from the bivariate relationship between the president's bargaining success and *Subcommittee distance*, along with subunit

TABLE 1 | Subcommittee composition and presidential budgetary success.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Subcommittee distance	0.209 (<0.001)	0.203 (<0.001)	0.374 (<0.001)	0.371 (<0.001)
ln(Request)		0.697 (<0.001)	0.696 (<0.001)	0.693 (<0.001)
Divided government			−0.327 (0.067)	−0.274 (0.172)
War			0.131 (0.038)	0.149 (0.016)
ln(Unemployment)				0.024 (0.946)
ln(GDP per capita)				2.371 (0.387)
ln(Deficit)				−0.002 (0.133)
Num.Obs.	10,761	10,761	10,761	10,761
R2	0.695	0.706	0.706	0.706
Subunit FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
President FE	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: Dependent variable is the absolute value of the difference (plus one), logged between a presidential budget request and the enacted appropriation. Entries are linear regression coefficients with *p*-values calculated using the wild bootstrap clustered on subcommittees in parentheses.

and president fixed effects. The second model adds the covariate characterizing the size of the president's budgetary proposal. In the third model, we add controls for divided government and war, and in the fourth model, we add a suite of economic and legislative controls described above.

The findings in Table 1 provided consistent evidence that presidents are less successful in achieving their preferred outcomes when their proposed budgets are reviewed by an ideologically distant legislative subcommittee. In each model, the coefficient for *Subcommittee distance* is positively signed and statistically distinguishable from zero. These findings indicate that the discrepancy between presidential requests and congressional enactments increases with the ideological distance between the president and the relevant subcommittee. Taking the inverse log of the coefficient from column 4 indicates that a standard deviation increase in the ideological distance between a president and the most distant subcommittee median translates to a 45% increase in the discrepancy between presidential proposals and congressional enactments. The magnitude of this difference is on par with or exceeds the effect size of factors found to be important in previous scholarship on presidential bargaining success, such as war (Howell and Jackman 2013), increased latitude on foreign policy issues relative to domestic affairs (Canes-Wrone et al. 2008), and presidents' public appeals (Canes-Wrone 2001, 2006). In short, ideological conflict between presidents and subcommittees reduces the president's influence over budgetary policy.

The results in Table 1 are robust across additional analyses. First, we considered several strategies to address budgets submitted by presidents in the first year of their terms. While presidents generally submit budget proposals in the first week of February (Dearborn 2019), new presidents are inaugurated only weeks before proposals are due. Newly inaugurated presidents thus decide whether to stand by their predecessor's budget proposal or submit their own. Every newly elected president in the post-World War II era made substantial revisions to their predecessor's proposal with the exception of George H.W. Bush (Keith and Christensen 2021). Following Howell et al. (2013), we estimated models where we omitted all observations from the first year of each presidential administration except Gerald Ford. We also estimated models where we omitted only the first year of George H.W. Bush's first term. Both analyses provide similar results to those shown in Table 1.¹⁶

Second, our results are robust to using an alternative measurement strategy for characterizing the ideological distance between presidents and subcommittees. By construction, the NOMINATE scores we use are constant over legislators' terms in office. While this choice is appropriate given perspectives that emphasize the ideological stability of legislators' voting records during their careers (Poole 2007), other evidence suggests that a legislator's voting record may vary across time depending on the political context (Howell et al. 2013) and, more relevant for our purposes, changes in committee membership. Moreover, the use of static NOMINATE scores means that changes in subcommittee ideology come only from compositional changes. As an alternative strategy, we estimate the models reported in Table 1 using Nokken-Poole scores to characterize the ideological locations of subcommittee members. Like NOMINATE scores, Nokken-Poole scores are comparable across time but allow a legislator's ideology to vary from one congressional term to the next. Our

results are nearly indistinguishable from Table 1 when substituting these scores.¹⁷

Third, we find no evidence that our results are driven by a single fiscal year, subcommittee, or component of the federal government. We re-estimated model (4) from Table 1 while sequentially omitting one year at a time. We repeated this exercise while omitting each subcommittee and each unit of government (“unit” generally refers to a department or similar institution). The coefficients from each of these 101 additional models continue to be positive and statistically distinguishable from zero, though the magnitude varies somewhat across the models.¹⁸ These results indicate that our findings are robust across the composition of our sample.

Fourth, we find that the composition of subcommittees is associated with differences in presidential budgetary success irrespective of the partisan composition of the House. Though some models in Table 1 controlled for periods of divided government, here we study whether the relationship between subcommittee distance and the president’s bargaining success varies with the composition of Congress. To do so, we estimated separate models for periods of unified and divided government, as well as included an interaction term with our measure of subcommittee distance. In model (3) we continue to obtain positive and statistically significant coefficients for subcommittee distance, while neither of the interaction terms is statistically distinguishable from zero.¹⁹ These results suggest that the composition of appropriations subcommittees is strongly linked to the president’s bargaining success regardless of whether the partisan composition of the House is favorable to the president. Even though the subcommittee distance measure is correlated with the partisan composition of the House, these results suggest that the findings in Table 1 do not simply reflect the larger congressional environment rather the membership of the relevant appropriations subcommittee.

Fifth, we sought to distinguish whether the composition of the House or Senate appropriations committees appeared to be the more binding constraint on presidential bargaining success. To do so, we estimated separate models in which *Subcommittee distance* was calculated based on the ideological distance between the president and the median of the relevant House and Senate appropriations subcommittees, respectively.²⁰ We find considerably stronger evidence that the House appropriations subcommittees are the strongest constraints on the president’s budgetary request. The coefficient for *Subcommittee distance* is approximately four times larger for the House subcommittees, while the coefficient for the Senate subcommittees is not statistically distinguishable from zero. These results underscore the importance of the House appropriations committees, consistent with classic accounts that focus on that chamber rather than the Senate.

Sixth, we assess the impact of *Subcommittee distance* relative to that of other key House of Representatives actors. Traditional theories of Congress highlight the importance of both subcommittee chairs (Berry and Fowler 2016) and the median member of the broader chamber (Krehbiel 1991). To evaluate the impact of these legislative actors, we estimated separate models for the ideological distance between the President and subcommittee

chairs as well as the median member of the House.²¹ To select the model that best represents the data-generating process, we compare the Bayesian Information Criterion (BIC) of the three models (Kuha 2004). The BIC represents an efficient method to evaluate nonnested models by calculating the probability that each model is the true model given our observed data (Bonneau et al. 2007). Our main specification in Table 1 performs the best among these three models. Moreover, we find that the coefficient for these alternative measures—*Subcommittee chair distance* and *House median distance*—is smaller than our main specification in Table 1.

Seventh, and finally, we study whether the relationship between subcommittee composition and presidential bargaining success systematically strengthened or weakened over the period under study. To do so, we considered the “Republican Revolution” as a potential break in the relationship between subcommittee composition and interbranch bargaining outcomes. Previous literature emphasizes that the Congress elected in the 1994 midterms marked an important turning point in congressional politics. In particular, a suite of reforms implemented with the new Republican majority weakened committee capacity (Crosson et al. 2021) and undermined the power of the HAC (Aldrich and Rhode 2000). We estimated separate models for budgets enacted prior to and after calendar year 1995.²² Interestingly, we find that the coefficient for *Subcommittee distance* is positive but small in magnitude and not statistically distinguishable from zero for the earlier period but large in magnitude and statistically significant for the period following the “Republican Revolution.” While the Republican Revolution may have inaugurated a period of decreased congressional influence vis-à-vis the president on other domains, our findings suggest that, if anything, Congress has been a more important source of constraint on the president during this period. Even in an era of reduced committee capacity, the decentralized nature of subcommittee organization is an important mechanism through which Congress constrains the president’s influence over discretionary spending.

We also considered changes over time by estimating the specification from column (4) of Table 1 while also including indicators for each decade in the period under study and interacting them with the measure of *Subcommittee distance*.²³ We find no systematic evidence of change over time. The coefficient for the constituent term of subcommittee distance is positive and statistically distinguishable from zero, as it is in Table 1. The interaction terms, moreover, are inconsistently signed, and only one (for the 2010s) is statistically significant at the 95% confidence level. Together, these findings weigh against claims that congressional constraints have declined or decreased over time.

4.1 | Do Presidents Anticipate Subcommittee Opposition?

To what extent are the results presented in Table 1 a result of strategic behavior by presidents? Though the findings support our theoretical perspective in which interbranch disagreement between presidents and subcommittees reduces Congress’s willingness to accommodate a president’s budgetary request, it is also possible that this result reflects presidents’ calculations

about how their proposals will be reviewed by Congress. If a president were to anticipate extra scrutiny from an appropriations subcommittee because the subcommittee membership is ideologically hostile to the president, for example, that president may decide to strategically misrepresent her preferences in the hope that enacted appropriations would end up somewhere close to what she ultimately would have preferred. In this case, a president who prefers more spending relative to Congress might submit a budget request that exceeds her own budgetary preferences (and analogously for a president who prefers lower spending than Congress). If this were to be the case, our findings would indicate not that subcommittees constrain presidential influence, but rather that presidents appear “weaker” when bargaining with ideologically distant subcommittees because of the president’s own strategic behavior.

Previous literature provides competing expectations about the potential for strategic behavior by presidents in this context. On the one hand, Kiewiet and McCubbins (1985a, 722) argue that presidents have strong incentives to represent their preferences truthfully to Congress. Likewise, presidents’ efforts to recruit public support for their proposals (e.g., Canes-Wrone 2001) suggest that presidents do not strategically manipulate their budgetary requests.²⁴ On the other hand, a considerable body of formal theory scholarship indicates the incentives for presidents to strategically represent their budgetary preferences in anticipation of how they will be received in Congress (see, e.g., Banks and Weingast 1992; Ferejohn and Krehbiel 1987). Likewise, empirical analyses of budget requests from agencies and presidents indicate that requests may not be sincere representations of spending preferences (LeLoup and Moreland 1978). We undertake two sets of analyses to address the possibility of strategic presidential proposal making.

First, we examine whether presidents request larger amounts when key members of Congress are more ideologically distant. Table 1 shows the results. In column (1), we regressed presidential proposals (logged) on the measure of subcommittee distance. In column (2), we add the indicator for divided government. Column (3) adds the indicator for periods of war and column (4) includes the battery of economic and war controls. If our findings reflect patterns of strategic presidential proposal making, we expect that presidents request more funding when facing ideologically divergent subcommittees and/or during periods of divided government.²⁵

We find no evidence that presidents increase or decrease their budgetary requests as the composition of Congress changes. None of the key coefficients in any model are large in magnitude or statistically distinguishable from zero. Moreover, even if the largest coefficient from Table 2 were statistically significant, it would explain only a fraction of the results we obtain in Table 1.²⁶ Overall, consistent with the argument from Kiewiet and McCubbins (1985a), Table 2 provides no evidence that presidents strategically manipulate their proposed budgets based on changes in the ideological composition of Congress.

Second, we estimate model specifications similar to those used in previous research to address potential endogeneity

TABLE 2 | Predicting the size of presidential requests.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Subcommittee distance	0.010 (0.350)	0.025 (0.231)	0.028 (0.180)	0.029 (0.172)
Divided government		−0.029 (0.345)	−0.035 (0.265)	−0.032 (0.328)
War			0.020 (0.298)	0.023 (0.198)
ln(Unemployment)				−0.013 (0.893)
ln(GDP per capita)				−0.334 (0.375)
ln(Deficit)				0.000 (0.152)
Num.Obs.	10,761	10,761	10,761	10,761
R2	0.937	0.937	0.937	0.937
Subunit FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
President FE	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: Dependent variable is the absolute value of the difference (plus one), logged between a presidential budget request and the enacted appropriation. Entries are linear regression coefficients with *p*-values calculated using the wild bootstrap clustered on subcommittees in parentheses.

between proposals and enacted appropriations. Following Kiewiet and McCubbins (1991) and Howell et al. (2013), we instrument logged presidential proposals on identifiers for first-term presidents and indicators for each of the four years in a presidential term in Appendix C.5. Unlike previous research, none of the instruments are statistically distinguishable from zero in our models, as the first-stage results are nearly identical to those shown in Table 2. Unsurprisingly, then, the *F*-statistic for our first-stage equation suggests that this instrumental variables strategy is extremely weak, as it is less than one. When estimating the second-stage results, the coefficient for subcommittee distance is identical to that shown in column (4) of Table 1—unsurprisingly, again, given that 2SLS estimates converge to OLS estimates in the context of weak instruments.

Overall, while the instrumental variables strategy used by prior research appears less reliable in the context of our data, the evidence weighs against the possibility that our main findings reflect strategic behavior by the president. This concern would require that presidents strategically increase their proposals when they anticipate greater opposition from Congress, which in turn makes them appear less successful than they actually are. In systematically investigating presidential budget requests, however, we find no evidence that presidents strategically modify their proposals as the composition of appropriations subcommittees changes. Thus, these findings are consistent with scholarship that argues that presidents have incentives to present sincere budgetary proposals and support our interpretation of the results shown in Table 1.

5 | Conclusions

Committees figure prominently in accounts of congressional policymaking, and no committee has been studied more than the House Appropriations Committee (see, e.g., Davis et al. 1966; Fenno 1962, 1966; Geiger 1994; Kingdon 1966; Lowery et al. 1985; MacMahon 1943; Sharkansky 1965a, Sharkansky 1965b; Woon and Anderson 2012). We make several contributions to this scholarship. First, we show how legislative committees affect policy outcomes. More precisely, we show how the ideological composition of appropriations subcommittees—primarily the House subcommittees—is associated with the subcommittees' willingness to enact budgets that reflect the president's preferences. Our results imply that appointments to subcommittees matter for the appropriations bills passed by Congress because differences in a subcommittee's composition would produce different funding levels for the agencies under its jurisdiction. Despite oft-repeated concerns about the demise of congressional committee power, we show that the composition of the appropriations subcommittees has important implications for contemporary budgetary outcomes.

Second, our findings highlight the mechanisms through which Congress can constrain presidents' efforts to affect executive branch policymaking. An important body of literature highlights the president's agenda-setting powers in appropriations (Dearborn 2019; Krause 2022) and documents the conditions that enhance the president's strategic position in this context (Canes-Wrone 2001; Canes-Wrone et al. 2008; Howell et al. 2013). Our findings offer a reminder of the institutional advantages that Congress wields as it negotiates public policy with the White House. The power of the purse has long been viewed as a powerful constraint on the presidency, and we offer evidence about how this institutional prerogative operates through the committee system. This finding complements other scholarship that demonstrates how interbranch conflict moderates presidents' abilities to achieve their political goals (e.g., Bolton and Thrower 2021; Howell 2003; Kiewiet and McCubbins 1988). Even more pointedly, our findings highlight the role of small subcommittees in enabling Congress to overcome collective action problems that otherwise would inhibit Congress's ability to constrain the policymaking influence of the president. Our results, along with other recent scholarship (Bolton and Thrower 2019), provide evidence about Congress's ability to affect policy outcomes through decentralized processes and organizational structures rather than through the centralization of power in party leadership (e.g., Cox and McCubbins 2007; Rohde 1991).

Even more generally, our account provides a framework through which we can evaluate how other features of the political environment affect interbranch bargaining. Given previous scholarship that stresses the conditions under which Congress defers to the president's preferences on policy debates (Howell and Jackman 2013; Kang 2022), we would expect that subcommittees better accommodate presidential budgetary requests despite their ideological differences when presidents are in politically advantageous positions. This might occur when, for example, presidential approval ratings are high (Christenson and Kriner 2019; Neustadt 1990) or on issues with significant public salience (e.g., Canes-Wrone 2001; Lee 2008). We have considered

possibilities such as these in supplementary analyses reported in Appendix D. We find no evidence that presidential popularity is associated with greater congressional deference to presidents' budgetary requests, nor do we find that the salience of an issue either to the public or to the president substantially moderates subcommittee scrutiny of presidents' budgets. These initial results suggest that the appropriations subcommittees play a robust role in enforcing Congress's institutional prerogatives, but further research to delineate the scope of this influence would be helpful for developing a fuller understanding of how the separation of powers operates in this domain.

Our analysis has some important limitations, however, and raises questions for further inquiry. First, while our account focuses on the ideological composition of the appropriations subcommittees, we noted the challenges in distinguishing their effects from other similar measures with which they are likely correlated. For example, a more conservative Congress is likely to have more conservative appropriations subcommittees and more conservative subcommittee chairs. Each of these actors plays important roles in scholarship on legislative outcomes, and it is empirically difficult to distinguish the unique effects of each. While our evidence supports our argument about subcommittees, our evidence does not suggest that other key legislative actors are not relevant. Second, while we considered the possibility that presidents strategically submit budget requests in anticipation of how legislators may respond, our empirical findings suggested that presidents do not behave in this way. While there may be good reasons for this, it is possible that presidents forgo some bargaining advantages by doing so. Further research would be useful to better understand how presidents craft their budget proposals based on their expectations about the congressional response. Third, our larger argument emphasized the role of committees and subcommittees in shaping policy outcomes. Further research studying outcomes beyond appropriations would be useful for generalizing the argument. It is also possible that committees could have heterogeneous influence on policy outcomes depending on their power and/or capacity. Additional scholarship could examine this by, for example, leveraging variation in the value legislators assign to committees (Groseclose and Stewart 1998) or measures of committee staff. Fourth, while our results suggest the role of subcommittees in structuring Congress's response to presidential budgets, it is unclear whether these outcomes have implications for the quality of political representation. Recent scholarship indicates that committee members are less responsive to constituent preferences on the issue area associated with the committee's jurisdiction (Olson and Rogowski 2024) but did not examine appropriations outcomes and subcommittees specifically. Further work in this area could help better identify the representational consequences of subcommittee influence. Finally, while our case focused on the politics of appropriations, it is unclear whether and how our findings might generalize to other (sub)committees and policy domains. These questions present important opportunities for scholars to take a fresh look at the politics of congressional committees and their role in the separation of powers.

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Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are openly available in Legislative Studies Quarterly Dataverse at <https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataverse/lsq>.

Endnotes

- ¹ For an alternative view about how these conditions affect the power of congressional leaders, see Bloch Rubin (2025).
- ² Interestingly, Richard Fenno's landmark study of the House Appropriations Committee seemed to forecast that the rise of party polarization would reduce committee power, noting that "nothing would be more disruptive to the Committee's work than bitter and extended partisan controversy" (Fenno 1962, 317).
- ³ This research also focuses nearly exclusively on the House, though more recent scholarship suggests the value of accounting for the Senate when evaluating appropriations outcomes (Hanson 2014; Shepsle et al. 2009).
- ⁴ Interestingly, the HAC was one of two committees for which the evidence in Groseclose (1994) supported the outlier hypothesis.
- ⁵ "Subunit" generally refers to federal offices and agencies, such as the Forest Service and the Federal Aviation Administration.
- ⁶ For continuing resolutions, this means that the level of funding would correspond to the actual value enacted for that subunit, not simply be populated with enactment data from the previous fiscal year.
- ⁷ We focus on discretionary spending because it is the primary site of interbranch bargaining between the president and Congress.
- ⁸ There are 388 subunits with negative proposal or enactment values. We filtered out these observations, since they mainly represent programs that were in the process of being phased out.
- ⁹ We describe these cases and how we handled them in Appendix A.3.
- ¹⁰ This period is often noted as one of stability for its consistent committee structure and subcommittee jurisdictions (Saturno 2021).
- ¹¹ For clarification, we refer to the House and Senate Appropriation subcommittees, as opposed to the policy standing committees.
- ¹² To clarify, all model specifications are at the subunit level.
- ¹³ One may be concerned that NOMINATE scores are calculated using the appropriations bills whose outcomes we study. However, appropriations bills concern a trivial fraction of all roll calls in a given congress, and thus estimates of roll call voting behavior—which are based on all votes cast over a legislator's career—are based on substantially more information beyond a member's votes on appropriations in a given congress. While one might re-estimate NOMINATE scores and exclude appropriations votes, this exercise would likely produce scores that are empirically indistinguishable from extant 1st dimension NOMINATE scores given the unidimensionality in roll call voting patterns (Poole and Rosenthal 1991).
- ¹⁴ Our account follows Black (1958) in assuming that (sub)committee deliberations operate by majority rule, where we would expect the median member of the subcommittee to be the relevant actor for collective decision-making.
- ¹⁵ This could arise because the party opposite the president has political incentives to attempt to reduce the president's political standing (see,

e.g., Lee 2016) and/or because its members have budgetary preferences that systematically differ from the president's.

- ¹⁶ See Tables B.3 and B.4 in the Supporting Information Appendix. When removing observations from all presidents' first years, as Howell et al. (2013) do, the magnitudes of the coefficients are a bit smaller than in Table 1 (and are not statistically distinguishable from zero in several models), but we are inclined to view this as an overly conservative approach given that virtually all first-year presidents did in fact submit their own budgets.
- ¹⁷ See Table B.5.
- ¹⁸ See Figures B.1–B.3.
- ¹⁹ See Table C.1.
- ²⁰ See Table C.2.
- ²¹ See Table C.3.
- ²² See Table C.4.
- ²³ See Table C.4.
- ²⁴ Similarly, Kousser and Phillips (2012) argue that governors have strong reputational and electoral incentives to present sincere budgetary requests and present evidence showing that governors do not adjust their budgetary proposals as the composition of state legislatures changes.
- ²⁵ Conducting this analysis requires us to assume symmetric loss in the president's budgetary calculus; that is, that a president's utility is equally affected by a deviation in either the positive or negative direction relative to their budget request (see Krause and Cook 2015).
- ²⁶ The coefficient for divided government in column (3) is the largest in magnitude, and if it were statistically significant, it would provide evidence that presidents increase their requests by about 4 % when they transition from unified to divided government. However, the *p*-value is quite large, and thus the results do not provide compelling evidence for such an interpretation.

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Supporting Information

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section. **Data S1:** lsq70028-sup-0001-Supinfo.pdf.